



MONTHLY UPDATE

Somalia: monthly update, July 2026

Edition of 2026-08-19 · 17 systems and instruments tracked, 10 of them not held

Developments recorded from artefacts published between 2026-07-01 and 2026-08-19 — July 2026 carried forward to the date of issue, so the report holds the nightly catch to the day it was cut. Sections follow the status report.

Summary of the month

The Central Bank published, for the first time, the sequence by which banks and mobile wallets are to reach a single national payment rail — and named the wallets, which carry most Somali transactions, as the piece still missing. Around it, a cluster of institution-building: a national cybersecurity risk framework, a university AI centre, a national startup network, a regulator memorandum with a private innovation hub, and a statistics-office pilot putting official microdata in the hands of domestic researchers. At state level, Hirshabelle moved a public charge onto the mobile-money rails its payers already use. Cabinet approved a third-generation passport plan in the first week of August.

Infrastructure

Data Storage

The national data centre went backwards in the telling. A facility described at a ministerial inspection in May 2025 as nearing completion was, on 7 August 2026, [described by the state minister for communications as planned](#), to strengthen digital infrastructure — said at the launch of an artificial-intelligence product by a private centre. Nothing in the record reconciles the two accounts, and the ministry's stated rationale, ending reliance on data storage outside the country, remains its own statement that government data sits offshore.

Cybersecurity

The National Communications Authority [launched a National Cybersecurity Risk Management Framework on 21 July 2026](#), following the national consultation held in April. It covers risk identification, regulatory compliance and institutional responsibilities. No compliance deadline, reporting duty or penalty is published alongside it, and it is the third instrument in a cyber stack assembled inside eighteen months, after the Cybersecurity Law of January 2026 and the incident response team that opened in March.

Digital public infrastructure

Data Exchange

The Auditor-General put a number on how far the state's own systems are from talking to each other. The 2025 annual audit finds [seven government revenue and financial-management systems not integrated with the state financial management information system](#), and records 66 legal-compliance breaches across 22 audited bodies covering 60.1% of the national budget, including US\$18.5m of contracts awarded without following committee procedures. It also finds that a [port and airport revenue-share operator's reporting of US\\$38.08m, of a combined US\\$42.24m, could not be verified](#). The audit report itself is not held, the seven systems are not named, and no remediation plan or timetable is reported against any of it.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Cabinet [approved a third-generation e-passport plan on 6 August](#). No issuance date is published, and it follows the clearance in February to adopt and print the East African Community e-passport.

Digital Payments and Fintech

On 26 July the Central Bank set out how the instant payment system is to reach the whole market: [14 commercial banks and eight mobile money and e-wallet providers once integration completes, on ISO 20022, carrying person-to-person, merchant, government-to-person and person-to-government flows, with business-facing services still in development](#). The system is operated by the Somalia Payment Switch, a joint venture of the Central Bank and 13 commercial banks, which the Governor described as a deliberate choice over central-bank-run infrastructure. One commitment is stated and undelivered: mobile money integration carries no published date.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

A [national single window is named as planned within a regional trade project, alongside a trade information portal and the existing customs and livestock traceability systems it is to connect to](#). It is stated in an agenda piece by the national trade facilitation coordinator rather than in an instrument, and no design, timetable or budget is published.

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Hirshabelle put [tariff-loaded card terminals at its border checkpoints, reported 25 July](#). The device holds the tariff schedule: an officer enters vehicle type, origin and category, the terminal returns the amount due, payment moves over mobile money into the government account with no merchant in between, and a QR-coded receipt posts to a central system in real time. It replaces paper vouchers carried up to 90km and hand-keyed, on a reconciliation cycle the state's finance minister puts at 30 to 45 days. [Collections at equipped posts are reported up 668.94% in the first quarter of 2026 against 2020, a figure that comes only from the rollout's backers](#).

Governance and regulation

Regional collaboration

The connection to the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System is [a target for before the end of 2026 rather than a concluded arrangement](#).

Data protection

The communications minister restated on 22 July the request that Meta [delay the rollout of WhatsApp usernames](#), first made in a regulator statement of 6 July. [The stated grounds are impersonation and fraud risk against a mobile-money system carrying about 155m transactions a month worth US\\$2.7bn, and the loss of phone-number traceability in the campaign against al-Shabab](#). Somalia is the second country after India to ask for a pause; no response from the platform is on record.

Artificial intelligence and the technology sector

AI

The Somali National University [launched an AI centre on 20 July](#) for research and digital skills. No funding, staffing or research programme is stated, and the country still holds no national artificial intelligence policy of any kind.

August added a product and an assessment. A private artificial-intelligence centre [launched Garad.ai on 7 August alongside the communications and technology ministry](#); the record describes the launch rather than the product, and states no capability, language coverage, user base or hosting arrangement for it. Separately a national AI readiness assessment is under way, [led by the same ministry with UNESCO and joined by a private university on 17 August](#), examining artificial-intelligence policy, data governance and higher-education capacity. No methodology, participant list, score or publication date is stated — so the assessment is, for now, the closest thing the country has to a policy position on the subject.

Innovation ecosystem

The National Communications Authority [signed a memorandum of understanding with iRise Hub on 30 July](#) covering innovation, entrepreneurship, digital skills, cybersecurity, research and public engagement. No figure, term or named deliverable appears in it, and no party is identified as funding any of it. What it does establish is a direction for the regulator itself, whose statutory work is licensing and spectrum.

A national startup network was [launched at the innovation forum in Mogadishu on 22 July](#), connecting startups to incubators, chambers of commerce and government agencies. It runs under a project funded by the European Union and implemented by UNIDO, which [reports 3,600 applications across three cohorts, about 500 entrepreneurs through foundational training and more than 200 startups incubated, against a stated backdrop of about 500,000 young people entering the labour market each year for about 80,000 new jobs](#). The same account states that intellectual-property legislation is being developed; no bill, text or timeline is on file.

Inclusion and capacity

Training and skills

In the north, the Somaliland administration [launched fixed-asset training for public financial accountability on 4 August](#). No participant total, system or completion date is stated, and the base carries no earlier position for it.

Research institutions

The Somali National Bureau of Statistics closed a three-day technical workshop on 30 July under a [university research partnership, training researchers from three partner universities in methodology, statistical analysis and scientific writing, and in working with the bureau's own household budget and labour force microdata](#). It is a pilot funded by the Swiss development agency with no amount stated. What it implies about the constraint is the substantive part: official statistics exist and are being offered to domestic researchers, which puts the limit on evidence-based policy at national analytical capacity rather than at data collection.

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